

power and improved weapons would make it difficult for them to bounce back. The Government spent an estimated \$1.6 billion on defence last year and plans to spend even more in 2009, an indication that it will make heavy outlays on consolidating its hold on areas taken from the Tigers. Military spokesman Brigadier Udaya Nanayakkara said the army had used new strategies to augment its new weaponry and recruitment drives.

But B. Nadesan, the Tiger's political wing leader, was quoted as saying that the Tiger leader was still in the island. "It is malicious propaganda. Our leader is still with us and our leader is giving leadership to our freedom struggle," the BBC quoted Nadesan as saying. "In a liberation war, it is normal for a force to lose territory and regain the same and achieve freedom," Nadesan said. "In the past, we have withdrawn many times and bounced

Cross (ICRC) said a "major humanitarian crisis is unfolding" and UN chief Ban ki Moon said he was "deeply concerned about the safety and well-being of civilians caught in intensified fighting". Both sides have been blaming each other for civilian casualties. On January 27, ICRC said in a statement that "hundreds" had been killed in the battle for Mullaitivu and added that medical facilities in the northern region are overwhelmed by "hun-

**PRESIDENT RAJAPAKSE (LEFT),
LTTE CHIEF PRABHAKARAN
AND TAMIL NADU CHIEF
MINISTER KARUNANIDHI
(EXTREME RIGHT)**

**WITH THE LTTE
CRUSHED AND
PRABHAKARAN
ON THE RUN,
RAJAPAKSE MAY
GO FOR A POLL.**



"We used small groups of four or eight soldiers to infiltrate Tiger lines and carry out attacks inside," Nanayakkara said, adding that while the military had swelled its numbers, the Tigers had sustained a heavy loss of combatants even as they were forced to yield territory that was in their control for over a decade. The army claimed it had killed 2,000 Tigers and wounded 3,000 in the year-long battle for the north-eastern district.

The LTTE may have lost their conventional fighting capability, but are expected to resort to the guerrilla tactics of suicide bombings, ambushes and sabotage attacks that they are well known for from bases deep in the jungle. There was speculation that V. Prabhakaran may have fled by sea.

back to achieve big victories." Prabhakaran's fate would be crucial for the LTTE and will determine how it will deal with the current debacle. Losing all its main urban centres and being left without a recruitment base, it will be difficult for the Tigers to keep up the momentum of its over 30-year-old separatist campaign and the motivation of its fighters. The Tigers, however, still have a support network among Sri Lankan Tamils overseas.

There is widespread concern for the estimated 2,50,000 people who have been displaced from their homes and caught between the military and the LTTE. They are in the "safety zone", a demilitarised area declared by the military as a civilian shelter. The International Committee of the Red

dreds of dead and scores of wounded". The Government has been insisting that there have been "zero civilian casualties" in the northern campaign and accused the LTTE of using civilians as cover for their operations. The pro-rebel Tamilnet website has claimed that civilians have died in army shelling. ICRC has appealed to both sides to allow the civilians to leave the combat zone.

The plight of Tamil civilians was one of the issues raised by External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee, who made a flying visit to the island on January 27. He won assurances from the Rajapakse government "that they would respect the safe zones and minimise the effects of conflict on Tamil civilians", a statement from the